

AVOID NOTES (DON'T EXIST)

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #80

For years (decades) I heard about the "avoid notes" on a given chord, notes that don't sound as good as others. And yes, there is some truth to that way of thinking. Here is a partial list of awful sounding notes on a given chord.

- The 4th on a major 7 chord
- The minor 7th on a major 7 chord
- The minor 3rd on a major 7 chord
- The major 3rd on a minor 7 chord
- The major 7th on a minor 7 chord
- The major 7th on a dominant chord

Another word for "avoid" or "awful" is Interesting. Or Flavorful. Or Tense, or Suspensful. These notes should NOT be avoided. Rather, they should be understood and loved. They should be cared for and nurtured. These are the fun notes, the notes your mother warned you about. Sure, they might get you in trouble now and again, but when you learn what makes them tick, learn a bit about how they work and how they resolve, you will begin to see inside what makes all great art work . . . tension and release. You can't have the release without the tension, and tension (melodic tension anyway) comes from the "avoid notes."

The example below uses a number of "avoid notes" (highlighted with the "V" symbol above the notes head). The chord changes used in the example here were addressed in Digging Deeper #79, "How To Learn Tunes." They are based on Take The A Train/Girl From Impanema.

The musical notation example consists of two staves in treble clef. The first staff begins with a **Fmaj7** chord and contains four measures. The second measure has a whole note G4 marked with a 'V'. The third measure has a half note A4 marked with a 'V'. The fourth measure has a half note Bb4 marked with a 'V'. The staff then changes to a **G7** chord for the next four measures. The first measure of the **G7** section has a whole note Bb4 marked with a 'V'. The second measure has a half note C5 marked with a 'V'. The third measure has a half note D5 marked with a 'V'. The fourth measure has a whole note E5 marked with a 'V'. The second staff begins with a **Gm7** chord and contains four measures. The first measure has a whole note Bb4 marked with a 'V'. The second measure has a half note C5 marked with a 'V'. The third measure has a half note D5 marked with a 'V'. The fourth measure has a whole note E5 marked with a 'V'. The staff then changes to a **C7** chord for the next four measures. The first measure of the **C7** section has a whole note D5 marked with a 'V'. The second measure has a half note E5 marked with a 'V'. The third measure has a half note F5 marked with a 'V'. The fourth measure has a whole note G5 marked with a 'V'. The staff then changes to a **Fmaj7** chord for the final four measures. The first measure of the **Fmaj7** section has a whole note G5 marked with a 'V'. The second measure has a half note A5 marked with a 'V'. The third measure has a half note Bb5 marked with a 'V'. The fourth measure has a whole note C6 marked with a 'V'. The piece ends with a final whole note C6 marked with a 'V'.